autonomy in nuclear families but did not change much in joint families. It also contributed to the feminization of the agricultural workforce with men taking up the relatively better paying jobs outside farms. In recent years, female migration rates—for marriage and work—within India have surged, but with little evidence of diversifications in occupations.[36] Outside India, the share of women among Indians is well below 50 per cent in nearly all countries where data is available, and in the Persian Gulf, it is less than 30 per cent. Initial waves of merchant migrants did not include women whereas Partition and involuntary displacements negatively impacted women. Women, like the lowest-ranking castes, have also been outside many circuits of migration characterized by better pay and upward mobility.

The ultimate form of exploitation of women was, of course, slavery. In ancient and medieval India, slavery targeted women in particular occupations like prostitution which continued through the colonial period. The male ghettoes of the cities in the Great Indian Migration Wave such as Calcutta and Bombay comprising both Indian and European labour and the elite had raised the demand for prostitution in the 19th century. The labour was provided by homeless or abandoned children and women, usually brought to the city by deception or force. In one official record in the late 19th century, a cultivator's girl was made to swap with a prostitute's boy because apparently neither was of any use to their natural parents.[37] Girls were trafficked to Indian settlements abroad, such as Fiji, by mercenary parents.[38]

Other female occupations of service to patrons also underwent a change in nature and perception. The courtesan *tawaif*s of Awadh moved to Calcutta after Awadh was annexed by the British in the 19th century, where they sought new patronage from the British and Bengali elite. However, their artistic contributions were devalued over time and replaced by sexual services. The nautch girls in music and dance at parties and functions were stigmatized for their 'immoral acts' and dubbed prostitutes. There was also a demand for 'white prostitutes' to serve the needs of the British soldiers. When anti-trafficking movements against the 'white slave trade' began in the early 20th century, colonial officials were careful to punish or deport